Manifesto for Love

28 poems / 28 countries
Six continents



VISIONING PRESS

Manifesto for Love

28 POEMS / 28 COUNTRIES / SIX CONTINENTS

The Manifesto for Love project gathers together poems, songs and stories from the world's 195 countries, in their original languages and translated into English.

This selection brings together 28 poems from 28 countries in six continents across time and cultures. Each poem tells stories of love in the language, place and time from which it comes.

The original text and English translation appear together, followed by a short history note. We have focused on poems that are out of copyright so we can share them easily.

Explore the full project
visioninglab.github.io/lovemanifesto

Kicôla!

Absolutely Not!

Joaquim Dias Cordeiro da Matta / Composed Luanda, 1877; published in Almanach, 1888

Original · Portuguese, with Kimbundu dialogue

Nesta pequena cidade,
vi uma certa donzela,
que muito tinha de bela,
de fada, huri e deidade,
a quem disse: - "minha q'rida,
peço um beijo por favor,
bem sabes ó meu amor,
que eu por ti daria a vida!"
- "Nguami-âmi, ngana-lame,
"não quero, caro senhor" –
disse, sem mudar de cor –
"maculo! quangandallâmi,
"não creio no vosso amor"...

Excerpt: opening passage

English translation

In this little town
I saw a certain maiden,
so full of beauty,
of fairy, houri and divinity,
to whom I said: "My darling,
please grant me a kiss;
you know well, my love,
that I would give my life for you!"
"Nguami-âmi, ngana-lame,
'I do not want to, dear sir,'"
she said, without changing colour;
"maculo! quangandallâmi,
'I do not believe in your love'..."

History

Cordeiro da Matta wrote in Luanda when Angola was a Portuguese colony, and is counted among the first Angolan poets. He also compiled a Kimbundu dictionary and collected proverbs, part of an early effort to value African languages under colonial rule; the woman in this poem answers in Kimbundu.

Força de Cretcheu

The Power of Love

Eugénio Tavares / Before 1930; included in Mornas – Cantigas Crioulas, 1932

Original · Cape Verdean Creole

Ca tem nada na es bida
Mas grande que amor
Se Deus ca tem medida
Amor inda é maior.
Maior que mar, que céu
Mas, entre tudo cretcheu
De meu inda é maior
Cretcheu más sabe,
É quel que é di meu
Ele é que é tchabe
Que abrim nha céu.
Cretcheu más sabe
É quel qui crem
Ai sim perdel
Morte dja bem

Excerpt: first two stanzas

English translation

There is nothing in this life
Greater than love;
If God has no measure,
Love is greater still.
Greater than the sea, than the sky,
But, above all, my own beloved
Is greater still.
The sweetest beloved
Is the one who is mine;
They are the key
That opens my heaven.
The sweetest beloved
Is the one who loves me;
Ah, if I lost them,
Death would come.

History

Eugénio Tavares, from the island of Brava, made the morna, Cabo Verde's slow song of longing, into poetry, and he wrote in Cape Verdean Creole when Portuguese colonial rule treated it as a mere dialect. Many of his mornas grew from the partings of an island of emigrants and sailors, and they are still sung today.

Caashaqa haween waa horuu Caaddil soo rogaye

Love of women was ordained long ago by the Just One

Cilmi Boodhari / Ilmi Bowndheri / 1930s, after the love encounter dated 1934 in the 1967 account; exact composition date uncertain

Original · Somali

Caashaqa haween waa horuu,
Caaddil soo rogaye,
Sayidkii carshiga nuurayiyo,
Caliba soo gaadhye,
Cidla lagama beermeen dadkoo,
cuudi waahhidahe,
Wahha caynba cayn looga dhigay,
hays cajebiyeene,
Soomaalidaa caado hhune, iguma caydeene.

English translation

Love for women was ordained long ago
by the Just One;
it touched even the Prophet of the shining
Throne, and Ali too.
People did not grow out of emptiness; they
come from one root,
and each kind was made unlike the next, so let
them not marvel at one another.
It is the Somalis whose custom is cruel; let
them not mock me.

Excerpt: five lines

History

Ilmi Boodhari was a poet of Berbera who, according to tradition, died around 1941 of love for a woman he could not marry. His love poems broke with the custom of keeping romantic feeling out of public Somali verse.

صلوات في هيكل الحب

Prayers in the Temple of Love

Abu al-Qasim al-Shabbi / 13 October 1931 (date printed with poem)

Original · Arabic

عذبةٌ أنتِ كالطفولةِ ، كالأحلامِ ،
كاللحنِ ، كالصباحِ الجديدِ
كالسماءِ الضحوكِ كالليلةِ القَمْراءِ ،
كالوردِ ، كابتسامِ الوليدِ
يا لها من وداعةٍ وجَمالِ
وشبابٍ مُنَعَّمٍ أُمْلُودِ !
يا لها من طهارةٍ ، تَبْعَثُ التقْديـ
ـسَ في مهجةِ الشَّقِيِّ العَنِيدِ ! . . .
يا لها رقَّةً تكادُ يَرُفُّ الوَرْ
دُ منها في الصخرةِ الجلمودِ !
أَيُّ شيءٍ أنتِ ؟! هل أنتِ «فينسُ»
تهادتْ بين الورَى من جديدِ
لِتُعِيدَ الشبابَ والفرحَ للمَغْـ
ـمُومِ لِلعالَمِ التعيسِ العَمِيدِ !
أم مَلاكُ الفردوسِ جاء إلى الأرْ
ضِ لِيُحْيِيَ روحَ السلامِ العَهِيدِ !
أنتِ . . . ، ما أنتِ ؟ رسمٌ جميلٌ
عبقريٌّ من فنِّ هذا الوجودِ
فيكِ ما فيه من غموضٍ وعُمْقٍ
وجمالٍ مُقَدَّسٍ معبودِ

Excerpt: opening ten couplets

English translation

You are sweet as childhood, as dreams,
as a melody, as a new morning,
as the laughing sky, as the moonlit night,
as the rose, as a newborn's smile.
What gentleness, what beauty,
what soft and supple youth!
What purity, that wakes reverence
even in the heart of the
wretched and stubborn!
What tenderness: roses could almost flutter
from it even in solid rock!
What are you? Are you Venus,
walking once more among humankind
to bring back youth and joy to the grieving,
to the miserable, heartsick world?
Or an angel of paradise come down to earth
to revive the spirit of a peace long gone?
You… what are you? A lovely picture,
a masterpiece of the art of this existence;
in you is all its mystery and depth
and its holy, worshipped beauty.

History

Abu al-Qasim al-Shabbi is Tunisia's national poet, writing when Tunisia was a French protectorate; lines from his poem "The Will to Live" are in the Tunisian national anthem. He died in 1934, aged 25.

عشق او باز اندر آوردم به بند

Love for him has bound me once again

Attributed to Rābiʿa Balkhi / 10th century (traditional attribution; precise date unknown)

Original · Persian / Dari

عشق او باز اندر آوردم به بند
کوشش بسیار نامد سودمند
عشق دریایی کرانه ناپدید
کی توان کردن شنا ای هوشمند
عشق را خواهی که تا پایان بری
بس که بپسندید باید ناپسند
زشت باید دید وانگارید خوب
زهر باید خورد وانگارید قند
توسنی کردم ندانستم همی
کز کشیدن تنگتر گردد کمند

Complete poem

English translation

Love for him has bound me once again;
all my struggling has been in vain.
Love is a sea whose shore is lost to sight—
how can you hope to swim it, prudent one?
If you would follow love through to its end,
you must accept so much you cannot bear:
see ugliness and reckon it as beauty,
drink poison and imagine it is sugar.
I struggled wildly, never understanding:
the more I pulled, the tighter
drew the snare.

History

Rābiʿa Balkhi lived in Balkh in the tenth century and is remembered as one of the first women to write poetry in Persian. Legend says her brother killed her for loving a servant named Baktash; her story mixes history and legend, and her shrine in Balkh is still visited today.

Şuri-eşqin başıma axırı sövda gətirir

The tumult of your love will finally drive me mad

Khurshidbanu Natavan / 19th century; exact date not established

Original · Azerbaijani

Şuri-eşqin başıma axırı sövda gətirir,
Bu müşəxəssdi ki, eşq aşiqə qovğa gətirir.
Tari-zülfündü məni böylə giriftar eləyib,
Nə gələ başıma, ol zülfi-mütərra gətirir.
Gül üzün görmək əgər mümkün
olaydı bir dəm,
Hər zaman görmək onu nuri-mücəlla gətirir.
Qaşü göz, novki-mücə fitnə
üçün cəm olmuş,
Ox atıb, tiğ çəkib, hər biri dəva gətirir.
Könlümü qarət edir eylə ki, tari-zülfün,
Rumə, sanki həbəşi ləşgəri-yəğma gətirir.

English translation

The tumult of your love will finally
drive me mad;
it is plain that love brings strife to the lover.
The strands of your hair have made me
such a captive;
whatever befalls me is brought by
those fresh tresses.
If only I could see your rose-like
face a moment:
each sight of it brings radiant light.
Eyebrow, eye and eyelash-tip have gathered
to cause unrest;
each shoots arrows, draws a sword and
brings a quarrel.
The strands of your hair plunder my heart
as though an Abyssinian army were bringing
pillage to Rum.

Complete poem

History

Khurshidbanu Natavan, daughter of the last khan of Karabakh, was one of the best-known women poets of the nineteenth-century Caucasus, then under Russian rule. In her home city of Shusha she led a literary circle and paid for the town's first water supply.

靜女

The Quiet Maiden

Anonymous; Shijing tradition / 1st millennium BCE (Shijing tradition; exact poem date unknown)

Original · Classical Chinese

靜女其姝,
俟我於城隅,
愛而不見,
搔首踟躕。

靜女其孌,
貽我彤管,
彤管有煒,
說懌女美。

自牧歸荑,
洵美且異,
匪女之為美,
美人之貽。

Complete poem

English translation

The quiet maiden is lovely;
she waits for me by the city wall.
She hides and does not appear;
I scratch my head and pace about.

The quiet maiden is beautiful;
she gives me a red reed.
The red reed shines;
I delight in your beauty.

From the pasture she brings a tender shoot,
truly lovely and unusual.
It is not the shoot itself that is beautiful:
it is a gift from my beautiful one.

History

This poem comes from the Shijing, or Book of Songs, China's oldest collection of poetry, gathered between about 1000 and 600 BCE. Tradition says Confucius chose its songs, and for two thousand years scholars read even its love songs as moral lessons.

Harum Rambutmu

The Fragrance of Your Hair

Amir Hamzah / Published 1932 in Timboel; collected in Buah Rindu (1941)

Original · Indonesian / literary Malay

Kupatah tangkai kusuma kukucup
Kendati mencari wangi asli
Cempaka tinggal tergulai lampai
Sayang tanganku hendak mencapai.

Teja! hanya cempaka ditayang daun
Aneka bunga menutup bumi
Impian lama datang mengalun
Kerana kusuma kenangan diri.

Harum rambutmu terasa ada
Dalam bunga duduk tersembunyi
Suma mana ratna mulia
Kanda sibuk tengah mencari

Pohon rendah dinaungi kemuning
Puteri dilindungi payung kembang
Bunga adinda kencana ramping
Irama kusuma abang seorang.

Wangi tertebar membawaku ragu
Mengambang abang ke hari lampau
Harum sepadan wangi rambutmu
Kalau terurai kita bergurau.

Melur! Duta rindu di purnama-raya
Kawan sendu di sunyi malam
Ratna rupa di hulu kemala
Penambah manis jiwa pendiam.

English translation

I break off a flower's stem and kiss it,
Though it is the true fragrance I am seeking;
The champak hangs, drooping and slender,
Alas, my hand longs to reach it.

Evening glow! only the champak is
    cradled by leaves,
Flowers of every kind cover the earth;
An old dream comes drifting back
Because of the flower of my own memory.

The fragrance of your hair I can sense
Sitting hidden within the flowers;
Which flower is the noble jewel
That I, your lover, am busy searching for?

A low tree shaded by kemuning,
A princess sheltered by a parasol of blossom;
My darling's flower, slender and golden,
The flower song of your lover alone.

The scattered scent fills me with doubt,
Your lover drifts back to days gone by;
A fragrance equal to the scent of your hair
When it was loosened and we
    laughed and teased.

Jasmine! Envoy of longing under the full moon,
Companion in sorrow in the silent night,
Jewel in form at the crown of gems,
Sweetening a quiet soul.

Complete poem

History

Amir Hamzah, from the royal family of Langkat in Sumatra, was the leading poet of the Pujangga Baru movement that shaped modern Indonesian literature. He wrote the poems of Buah Rindu (Fruits of Longing) as a young man in Java; he was killed in 1946, in the violent upheaval that followed independence.

しのぶれど

Though I concealed it

Taira no Kanemori / 10th century (poem); c. 1235 (anthology compilation)

Original · Japanese

しのぶれど
色に出でにけり
わが恋は
物や思ふと
人の問ふまで

Complete poem

English translation

Though I tried to hide it,
it has shown itself in my face—
this love of mine—
until people ask me,
Are you lost in thoughts of someone?

History

Taira no Kanemori was a court poet of Heian Japan, where poems were part of courtship itself. This one won a famous poetry contest at the imperial palace in 960, and was later chosen for the Hyakunin Isshu, a hundred poems still used in a popular New Year card game.

동짓달 기나긴 밤을

The long winter-solstice night

Hwang Jini / 16th century, traditional attribution

Original · Korean

冬至ㅅ둘 기나긴 밤을
　　한허리를 버혀 내여
春風 니불 아레 서리서리 너헛다가
어론 님 오신 날 밤이여든
　　구뷔구뷔 펴리라

Complete poem

English translation

I will cut the waist from the long, long night
　　of the midwinter month,
and fold it, coil upon coil, under a quilt of
　　spring breeze,
and on the night my love comes home,
　　unroll it, fold by fold.

History

Hwang Jini was a sixteenth-century gisaeng, a performer and artist of the Joseon world, from Kaesong, now in North Korea. Only a handful of her sijo survive, and this one, about saving the long winter night for her lover's return, is among the most famous poems in Korean.

ਰਾਂਝਾ ਰਾਂਝਾ ਕਰਦੀ ਨੀ ਮੈਂ

Calling Ranjha, Ranjha, I myself have become Ranjha

Bulleh Shah / 18th century (exact composition date unknown)

Original · Punjabi

ਰਾਂਝਾ ਰਾਂਝਾ ਕਰਦੀ ਨੀ ਮੈਂ
ਆਪੇ ਰਾਂਝਾ ਹੋਈ।
ਸੱਦੋ ਨੀ ਮੈਨੂੰ ਧੀਦੋ ਰਾਂਝਾ
ਹੀਰ ਨਾ ਆਖੋ ਕੋਈ।
ਰਾਂਝਾ ਮੈਂ ਵਿੱਚ ਮੈਂ ਰਾਂਝੇ ਵਿੱਚ
ਹੋਰ ਖਿਆਲ ਨਾ ਕੋਈ।
ਮੈਂ ਨਹੀਂ ਉਹ ਆਪ ਹੈ ਆਪਣੀ
ਆਪ ਕਰੇ ਦਿਲਗੋਈ।
ਹੱਥ ਖੂੰਡੀ ਮੇਰੇ ਅੱਗੇ ਮੰਗੂ
ਮੋਢੇ ਕੂਰਾ ਲੋਈ।
ਬੁਲ੍ਹਾ ਹੀਰ ਸਲੇਟੀ ਵੇਖੋ
ਕਿੱਥੇ ਜਾ ਖਲੋਈ।

Complete poem

English translation

Calling “Ranjha, Ranjha”, O friends,
I myself have become Ranjha.
Call me Dhido Ranjha, friends;
let no one call me Heer.
Ranjha is in me, I am in Ranjha;
there is no other thought.
It is not I: it is he himself
who comforts his own heart.
A herder’s staff in my hand, the
herd before me,
a brown blanket on my shoulders.
Bulleh, look at Heer of the Sial clan:
where has she come to stand!

History

Bulleh Shah, an eighteenth-century Sufi poet from Kasur, now in Pakistan, retold the Punjabi love story of Heer and Ranjha as a song of the soul’s union with God. It is shown here in Gurmukhi script, as in the linked edition; in Pakistan Punjabi is usually written in Shahmukhi.

Muhabbatsiz kishi odam emasdur

A person without love is not truly human

Nodira / Early 19th century; before author's death in 1842

Original · Uzbek

Na gul sayr ayla, na fikri bahor et,
Jahondin kech, xayoli vasli yor et.
Muhabbatsiz kishi odam emasdur,
Gar odamsan, muhabbat ixtiyor et.
Uzoru qaddu raftoringni ko'rsat,
Chaman sarvu gulini sharmisor et.
Labi maxmurdadurmen, jomi may tut,
Karam qil, soqiyo, daf'i humor et.
«Analhaq» mojarosin aylading fosh,
kel, ey Mansur, istiqboli dor et.
Duru ashku aqiqi xuni dilni
Kelu yoring ayog'ig'a nisor et.
Kuyib, ey Nodira, olam elig'a
Muhabbat shevasini oshkor et.

English translation

Do not stroll among the roses, do not
think of spring:
give up the world, and dream of union with
your beloved.
A person without love is not truly human:
if you are human, choose love.
Show your cheek, your stature
and your walk,
and put the garden's cypress and
rose to shame.
My lips are parched with longing; hand me
the cup of wine;
be generous, cupbearer, and ease
my aching head.
You made public the secret of "I
am the Truth":
come, O Mansur, go out to
meet the gallows.
The pearls of your tears, the carnelian of
your heart's blood:
come, and scatter them at your
beloved's feet.
Burning, O Nodira, before the
people of the world,
reveal the ways of love.

Complete poem

History

Nodira was a poet and, for a time, ruler of the Kokand Khanate, governing on behalf of her son. She wrote in Uzbek, Persian and Tajik, and was executed in 1842 when the emir of Bukhara conquered Kokand.

Miếng trầu / Mời trầu

A Piece of Betel / Offering Betel

Hồ Xuân Hương / Late 18th–early 19th century; exact date not established

Original · Vietnamese

Quả cau nho nhỏ miếng trầu hôi
Này của Xuân Hương đã quệt rồi
Có phải duyên nhau thì thắm lại
Đừng xanh như lá bạc như vôi

English translation

A tiny areca nut, a humble betel quid:
here, Xuân Hương has already spread
the lime on it.
If we are fated for each other, let it
turn deep red;
do not stay green as the leaf, or turn pale
and faithless as the lime.

Complete poem

History

Hồ Xuân Hương, writing around 1800, is called the “queen of Nôm poetry”, poetry in Vietnamese written in its old characters. Her witty, often daring poems mocked the double standards imposed on women; offering betel was the traditional opening of a courtship.

Erklärung

Declaration

Ada Christen / 1868 (Lieder einer Verlorenen)

Original · German

Ich hörte heute deine Schwüre –
Und es bewegt das Herz mir nicht,
Glaub’ ich auch selbst, daß heiße Liebe
Aus jedem deiner Worte spricht.
Denn unwillkürlich muß ich denken
Der Zeit, wo du dich wirst bemühn,
Mit leeren Phrasen zu verhüllen
Des leeren Herzens matt’res Glühn.
Wo endlich du des Kämpfens müde
Und satt der selbstgewählten Ketten,
Schamlos dein eignes Wort verleugnend,
Ein Judas vor mich hin wirst treten.

Excerpt: 12-line passage

English translation

Today I heard your vows—
and they did not stir my heart,
though I myself believe that ardent love
speaks from every word you say.
For I cannot help but think
of the time when you will try
to hide in empty phrases
the fading glow of an empty heart;
when, weary at last of struggling,
and tired of chains you chose yourself,
shamelessly denying your own word,
you will stand before me as a Judas.

History

Ada Christen grew up poor in Vienna and worked as an actress before she published her first poems. Lieder einer Verlorenen ('Songs of a Lost Woman', 1868) shocked readers with its frank picture of poverty and women's lives, and this poem's distrust of fine words comes from that experience.

Ode to Aphrodite

Sappho / c. 600 BCE (approximate composition period)

Original · Ancient Greek

κῶττι μοι μάλιστα θέλω γένεσθαι
μαινόλᾳ θύμῳ· τίνα δηῦτε Πείθω
μαῖς ἄγην ἐς σὰν φιλότατα, τίς σ', ὦ
Ψάπφ', ἀδικήει;

καὶ γὰρ αἰ φεύγει, ταχέως διώξει,
αἰ δὲ δῶρα μὴ δέκετ' ἀλλὰ δώσει,
αἰ δὲ μὴ φίλει, ταχέως φιλήσει
κωὐκ ἐθέλοισα.

ἔλθε μοι καὶ νῦν, χαλεπᾶν δὲ λῦσον
ἐκ μεριμνᾶν, ὅσσα δὲ μοι τελέσσαι
θῦμος ἰμέρρει, τέλεσον· σὺ δ' αὔτα
σύμμαχος ἔσσο.

Excerpt: final three stanzas

English translation

And what I most wish to happen
For my maddened heart. "Whom now
shall I persuade
To lead you back into her love? Who, O
Sappho, wrongs you?

For if she flees, soon she will pursue;
If she will not take gifts, she will give them;
And if she does not love, soon she will love,
Even against her will."

Come to me now as well, and free
me from harsh
Cares; all that my heart longs
To bring about, bring about;
and you yourself
Be my ally.

History

Sappho lived on the island of Lesbos around 600 BCE and was so admired that later Greeks called her the tenth Muse. Almost all her work is lost; this prayer to Aphrodite is the only poem to survive complete, because an ancient critic quoted it as an example of perfect style.

Be bažnyčios, be altorių

Without a Church, without Altars

Salomėja Nėris / 1931 (first published in Pėdos smėly)

Original · Lithuanian

Be bažnyčios, be altorių,
Be sumainymo žiedų...
Žirgai skrenda, kiek tik nori,
Skrendam, lekiam vienu du!

Balti vėjai plaukus glosto
Jau toli žmonių garsai –
Iš auksinio žvaigždžių sosto
Štai, mus laimina Jisai!

Jis, kurs davė žmogui širdį
Su troškimais neramiais,
Vasaros vynu nugirdė –
Jis ir nuodėmes atleis!

Be bažnyčios, be altorių...
Žirgai lekia žvengdami –
Lekia, lekia musų norai
Nesulaikomi, jauni!

Complete poem

English translation

Without a church, without altars,
Without exchanging rings…
The horses fly as far as they please,
We fly, we race, just the two of us!

White winds stroke our hair,
The voices of people are already far away —
From the golden throne of the stars,
Look, He is blessing us!

He who gave the human heart
Its restless longings,
And made it drunk on summer wine —
He will forgive our sins as well!

Without a church, without altars…
The horses race on, neighing —
Our desires race, race on,
Unstoppable and young!

History

Salomėja Nėris was one of Lithuania's most loved poets. This poem comes from her 1931 collection Pėdos smėly (Footprints in the Sand); its lovers' wedding "without church or altars" was a daring image in Catholic Lithuania between the wars.

Rima XXI - ¿Qué es poesía?

Rhyme XXI — What Is Poetry?

Gustavo Adolfo Bécquer / 1871 (posthumous Rimas collection; not asserted as first printing of this poem)

Original · Spanish

—¿Qué es poesía?—dices mientras clavas
En mi pupila tu pupila azul;—
¿Qué es poesía? ¿Y tú me lo preguntas?
Poesía... eres tú.

English translation

What is poetry? you ask, fixing
your blue eyes upon my own.
What is poetry? And you ask me?
Poetry… is you.

Complete poem

History

Bécquer's Rimas were gathered by friends and published in 1871, the year after his early death. Short, musical and personal, they broke with grand Romantic rhetoric and shaped modern poetry in Spanish; 'poetry is you' is among the most quoted lines in the language.

Zwei Segel

Two Sails

Conrad Ferdinand Meyer / 1882 (Gedichte collection)

Original · German

Zwei Segel erhellend
Die tiefblaue Bucht!
Zwei Segel sich schwellend
Zu ruhiger Flucht!
Wie eins in den Winden
Sich wölbt und bewegt,
Wird auch das Empfinden
Des andern erregt.
Begehrt eins zu hasten,
Das andre geht schnell,
Verlangt eins zu rasten,
Ruht auch sein Gesell.

Complete poem

English translation

Two sails brighten
the deep-blue bay!
Two sails swell
for a tranquil flight!
As one, in the winds,
arches and moves,
the feelings of the other
are stirred as well.
If one longs to hurry,
the other moves swiftly;
if one wishes to rest,
its companion rests too.

History

Conrad Ferdinand Meyer of Zurich came to poetry late, after years of depression, and married Louise Ziegler in 1875. Zwei Segel, with its two sails moving as one, is often read as an image of that marriage.

Хотіла б я тебе, мов плющ, обняти

I would embrace you like ivy

Lesya Ukrainka / 16 November 1900 (composition)

Original · Ukrainian

Хотіла б я тебе, мов плющ, обняти,
Так міцно, щільно, і закрить од світа,
Я не боюсь тобі життя одняти,
Ти будеш мов руїна, листом вкрита, —
Плющ їй дає життя, він обіймає,
Боронить від негоди стіну голу,
Але й руїна стало так тримає
Товариша, аби не впав додолу.
Їм добре так удвох, — як нам з тобою, —
А прийде час розсипатись руїні, —
Нехай вона плюща сховає під собою.
Навіщо здався плющ у самотині?

English translation

I would embrace you like ivy,
so tightly, closely, hiding you
from the world.
I am not afraid of taking your life:
you would be like a ruin covered in leaves.
Ivy gives it life, embraces it,
protects its bare wall from the weather;
but the ruin, too, holds fast
its companion, lest it fall to the ground.
They are happy together—as we are—
and when the time comes for the
ruin to crumble,
let it bury the ivy beneath it.
What use has ivy for solitude?

Excerpt: opening 12 of 16 lines

History

Lesya Ukrainka wrote when Ukraine was divided between the Russian and Austro-Hungarian empires, and printing in Ukrainian was restricted in Russia. She wrote this in 1900, while caring for Serhiy Merzhynsky, the man she loved, who was dying of tuberculosis.

A él — En la aurora lisonjera

To Him — In the flattering dawn

Gertrudis Gómez de Avellaneda / 19th century; linked text categorized as published in 1871

Original · Spanish

Volaban los años, y yo vanamente
Buscando seguía mi hermosa visión...
Mas dio al fin la hora; brillar vi tu frente,
Y «es él», dijo al punto mi fiel corazón.
Porque era, no hay duda, tu imagen querida,
-Que el alma inspirada logró adivinar-
Aquella que en alba feliz de mi vida
Miré para nunca poderla olvidar.
Por ti fue mi dulce suspiro primero;
Por ti mi constante, secreto anhelar
Y en balde el destino -mostrándose fiero-
Tendió entre nosotros las olas del mar.

English translation

The years flew by, and still, in vain,
I went on searching for my beautiful vision…
But at last the hour came; I saw
your brow shine,
And “It is he,” my faithful heart said at once.
For it was, beyond doubt, your
beloved image
— which my inspired soul had
managed to divine —
The one I saw in the happy dawn of my life
And have never been able to forget.
For you was my first sweet sigh;
For you my constant, secret longing;
And in vain did fate, showing its cruelty,
Stretch the waves of the sea between us.

Excerpt: 12 lines from the second part

History

Gertrudis Gómez de Avellaneda left Cuba for Spain as a young woman and became one of the great Romantic writers in Spanish. Her novel Sab (1841) is one of the earliest novels in Spanish to condemn slavery.

Choucoune

Oswald Durand / 1884 (date printed with poem)

Original · Haitian Creole

Dériè gnou gras touff' pingouin,
L'aut'jou, moin contré Choucoune ;
Li sourit, l'heur'li ouè moin,
Moin dit : « Ciel ! A là bell' moune ! »
Li dit : « Ou trouvé ca cher ! »…
P'tits zoézeaux ta pé couté nous lan l'air…
Quand moin songé Ça, moin
gangnin la peine,
Car dimpi jou-là, dé pieds moin lan chaîne !
Ca qui pis trist'lan tout ça,
Ca qui va surprendr'tout moune,
Cé 'pou ouè malgré temps-là,
Moin aimé toujours Choucoune !

English translation

Behind a thick clump of cactus,
The other day, I met Choucoune;
She smiled the moment she saw me,
I said: "Heavens! What a beautiful girl!"
She said: "You think so, dear?"…
Little birds were listening to us
up in the air…
When I think of it, I am full of sorrow,
For since that day both my
feet are in chains!
The saddest thing in all of this,
The thing that will surprise everyone,
Is to see that, in spite of it all,
I still love Choucoune!

Excerpts: opening stanza and first four lines of the final stanza

History

Oswald Durand was the most celebrated Haitian poet of his day, and he wrote Choucoune (1884) in Haitian Creole while in prison; set to music, it became a beloved song and later the English hit "Yellow Bird". In the poem, Choucoune leaves the narrator for a white foreigner, a story that carried the weight of race and power in a country that had freed itself from French slavery in 1804.

A Red Flower

Claude McKay / 1922 (Harlem Shadows edition)

Original · English

Your lips are like a southern lily red,
Wet with the soft rain-kisses of the night,
In which the brown bee buries deep its head,
When still the dawn's a silver sea of light.

Your lips betray the secret of your soul,
The dark delicious essence that is you,
A mystery of life, the flaming goal
I seek through mazy pathways strange and new.

Your lips are the red symbol of a dream.
What visions of warm lilies they impart,
That line the green bank of a fair blue stream,
With butterflies and bees close to each heart!

Excerpt: opening 12 lines

History

Claude McKay grew up in rural Jamaica, then a British colony, and moved to the United States in 1912. Harlem Shadows (1922) helped launch the Harlem Renaissance, and his poems speak of love and beauty as well as protest against racism.

Wild nights! Wild nights!

Emily Dickinson / 1891 (first publication in Poems, Series Two)

Original · English

Wild nights! Wild nights!
Were I with thee,
Wild nights should be
Our luxury!

Futile the winds
To a heart in port, —
Done with the compass,
Done with the chart.

Rowing in Eden!
Ah! the sea!
Might I but moor
To-night in thee!

Complete poem

History

Emily Dickinson wrote nearly 1,800 poems in Amherst, Massachusetts, but only about ten were published in her lifetime. Her first editors hesitated over printing this one in 1891 because of its passion; whom it was written for is still debated.

Via Láctea, sonnet XIII — Ouvir estrelas

Milky Way, sonnet XIII — Listening to Stars

Olavo Bilac / 1888 (Via Láctea collection publication)

Original · Portuguese

"Ora (direis) ouvir estrelas! Certo
Perdeste o senso!" E eu vos
    direi, no entanto,
Que, para ouvi-las, muita vez desperto
E abro as janelas, pálido de espanto...
E conversamos toda a noite, enquanto
A via-láctea, como um pálio aberto,
Cintila. E, ao vir do sol,
    saudoso e em pranto,
Inda as procuro pelo céu deserto.
Direis agora: "Tresloucado amigo!
Que conversas com elas? Que sentido
Tem o que dizem, quando estão contigo?"
E eu vos direi: "Amai para entendê-las!
Pois só quem ama pode ter ouvido
Capaz de ouvir e de entender estrelas".

English translation

"What, listening to the stars!" you
    will say. "Surely
you have lost your senses!" Yet
    I shall tell you
that often I wake to hear them
and open the windows, pale with wonder.
And we converse all night, while
the Milky Way, like an open canopy,
glitters. At sunrise, longing and in tears,
I still seek them across the empty sky.
Now you will say: "My crazy friend!
What do you discuss with them?
    What meaning
is there in what they say when they
    are with you?"
And I shall tell you: "Love, to
    understand them!
For only one who loves can have an ear
able to hear and understand the stars."

Complete poem

History

Olavo Bilac published this sonnet in 1888, the year slavery was finally abolished in Brazil and a year before the empire became a republic. He was the leading poet of Brazil's Parnassian movement, admired for polished, musical sonnets like this one.

Tesa hu mokõime

To Two Black Eyes

Ignacio Alberto Pane / Before 1920; precise composition/first-print date unknown

Original · Guaraní

Chopĩ haitýpe mokói oĩva,
ndojohejávai maramoĩte;
peteĩchaitéva hũngue porãme
ha iporãnguépe katu kõingue.
Upe hũnguépe he'i jakúpe
ha pyharépe: tapomohũ.
Tesapehápe he'i jasýpe
ku oike potávo: toroipyru.
Ma'ẽ saguýpe jahechapáma
Ka'a pa'ũme kuarahysẽ
ha om'ẽmbápe nahesakãiri
hendy porãnte jasyichaite.
Mba'e mbyasýpe "luto" voíva
ha vy'aháipe tory rupa
Ma'ẽ hatãme chemopirĩva
ma'ẽ mbeguépe chemoãngaipa.
Omoporãva kuñataĩnguéra
jáma hi'áva, jáma hete,
pe pende jara noikotevẽiri
porã oñohẽgui pende pire.

Complete poem

English translation

Two thrushes that are in their nest
and never part from each other,
alike in their beautiful blackness
and twins in their beauty.
For their blackness they say to the pheasant
and to the night: we will out-darken you;
for their shine they say to the moon,
as it goes in: we will take your place.
When they glance sideways, it is as if we saw
the sun rising between the woods,
and when they look straight, they do
not merely shine:
they blaze as brightly as the moon.
For sorrow they are ready mourning,
for joy a spring of delight;
in hard looks they make me shiver,
in soft looks they make me sin.
What makes young women beautiful,
their hair, their figure,
your mistress does not need,
for beauty overflows from you.

History

Ignacio Alberto Pane was a Paraguayan poet, teacher and politician who wrote in both Spanish and Guaraní, the Indigenous language spoken by most Paraguayans. Writing poetry in Guaraní was a statement of pride at a time when educated society favoured Spanish.

Idilio muerto

A Dead Idyll

César Vallejo / 1919 (Los heraldos negros edition)

Original · Spanish

Qué estará haciendo esta hora mi
andina y dulce Rita
de junco y capulí;
ahora que me asfixia Bizancio, y que dormita
la sangre, como flojo cognac, dentro de mí.
Dónde estarán sus manos que en
actitud contrita
planchaban en las tardes
blancuras por venir;
ahora, en esta lluvia que me quita
las ganas de vivir.
Qué será de su falda de franela; de sus
afanes; de su andar;
de su sabor a cañas de mayo del lugar.
Ha de estarse a la puerta
mirando algún celaje,
y al fin dirá temblando: «Qué
frío hay... Jesús!»
y llorará en las tejas un pájaro salvaje.

English translation

What can my sweet Andean Rita be
doing at this hour,
Rita of reeds and wild cherries,
now that Byzantium stifles me,
and my blood
drowses inside me like weak cognac?
Where can her hands be, which, as
if in penitence,
ironed in the evenings
whitenesses still to come,
now, in this rain that takes from me
the wish to live?
What has become of her flannel skirt, of her
toil, of her walk,
of her taste of the local May sugar cane?
She must be standing at the door, watching
the sunset clouds,
and at last she will say, shivering: "How
cold it is... Jesus!"
and on the roof tiles a wild bird will weep.

Complete poem

History

César Vallejo wrote this in Lima, homesick for the Andean town of Santiago de Chuco where he grew up, and published it in his first book, Los heraldos negros (1919). He later moved to Paris and died there in 1938; he is often called the greatest Peruvian poet.

Explosión

Explosion

Delmira Agustini / 1907 (El libro blanco)

Original · Spanish

¡Si la vida es amor, bendita sea!
¡Quiero más vida para amar! Hoy siento
que no valen mil años de la idea
lo que un minuto azul del sentimiento.
Mi corazón moría triste y lento...
Hoy abre en luz como una flor febea;
¡la vida brota como un mar violento
donde la mano del amor golpea!
Hoy, partió hacia la noche, triste, fría,
rotas las alas mi melancolía;
como una vieja mancha del dolor
en la sombra lejana se deslíe...
¡Mi vida toda canta, besa, ríe!
¡Mi vida toda es una boca en flor!

English translation

If life is love, then let it be blessed!
I want more life in which to love! Today I feel
that a thousand years of thought
    are worth less
than one blue minute of feeling.
My heart was dying, slowly and sadly...
Today it opens into light like a
    flower of the sun;
life surges like a violent sea
where the hand of love strikes!
Today my melancholy, sad and cold,
its wings broken, departed into the night;
like an old stain of sorrow
it dissolves in the distant darkness...
My whole life sings, kisses, laughs!
My whole life is a mouth in bloom!

Complete poem

History

Delmira Agustini published this poem at 20 and became one of the first women in Latin America to write openly about desire. In 1914 she was killed by her former husband, weeks after a divorce made possible by Uruguay's new divorce law.

Camomile Tea

Katherine Mansfield / 1916 (composition); 1923 (collection publication)

Original · English

How little I thought, a year ago,
In that horrible cottage upon the Lee
That he and I should be sitting so
And sipping a cup of camomile tea.

Light as feathers the witches fly,
The horn of the moon is plain to see;
By a firefly under a jonquil flower
A goblin toasts a bumble-bee.

We might be fifty, we might be five,
So snug, so compact, so wise are we!
Under the kitchen-table leg
My knee is pressing against his knee.

Excerpt: lines 5-16

History

Katherine Mansfield left New Zealand for London at 19 and became one of the great short-story writers in English. She wrote this poem in 1916, months after her brother was killed in the First World War, and died of tuberculosis in 1923, aged 34.

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Edited by

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